

Extreme Recall: Which Politicians Come to Mind?

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In November 2013, we surveyed participants through Amazon’s Mechanical Turk (see [Berinsky, Huber and Lenz 2012](#)); 344 respondents contribute identified, score-matched free recalls to the analysis. (See [SI 1.1](#) for a description of how we processed this data, and comparison to population benchmarks.) We asked the respondents, “When you think about the Democratic (Republican) party, which political leader(s) first come to mind? Name up to three.” We followed the open-ended question with a multiple-choice question that presented respondents a list of names and photos of political leaders and asked the respondents “Is there another political leader that you haven’t mentioned already who immediately comes to mind when you think about the Democratic (Republican) party?” Among the Democrats, people choose between, Joseph Biden, Barney Frank, Bill Clinton, Hillary Clinton, Harry Reid, Ted Kennedy, Franklin Roosevelt, John Kerry, John Kennedy, Nancy Pelosi, Al Gore, Barack Obama. And among Republicans, between, Paul Ryan, John McCain, Rand Paul, Sarah Palin, Ronald Reagan, George W. Bush, John Boehner, Jeb Bush, Michele Bachmann, Ted Cruz, Chris Christie, Marco Rubio, Eric Cantor, Mitt Romney, and Mitch McConnell. We paired the responses with CF-Scores ([Bonica 2013](#)).

Respondents rated the first two freely recalled names and the prompted selection from each party on a seven-point liberal–conservative scale. There was no rating of the third free

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recall. Our primary rating analysis uses free recalls; the appendix also reports prompted selections and the pooled sample.

We find that people are likelier to recall prominent politicians (see Figure 1). On average, the people recall politicians who are no more extreme than the median member of Congress. For instance, recalled politicians are more extreme than the Senate mean just 55.6% of the times. And the average difference to the Senate means is a mere .017 (see 1). (For comparison, the standard deviation of CF-scores within the parties in the Senate is about .3.) People do recall more extreme politicians earlier but again the bias is substantively not particularly large. However, people tend to *think* that these relatively moderate politicians are ideologically extreme (see SI 1.1). Thus, the bias may be less in who is covered in the media, and more about how they are covered.

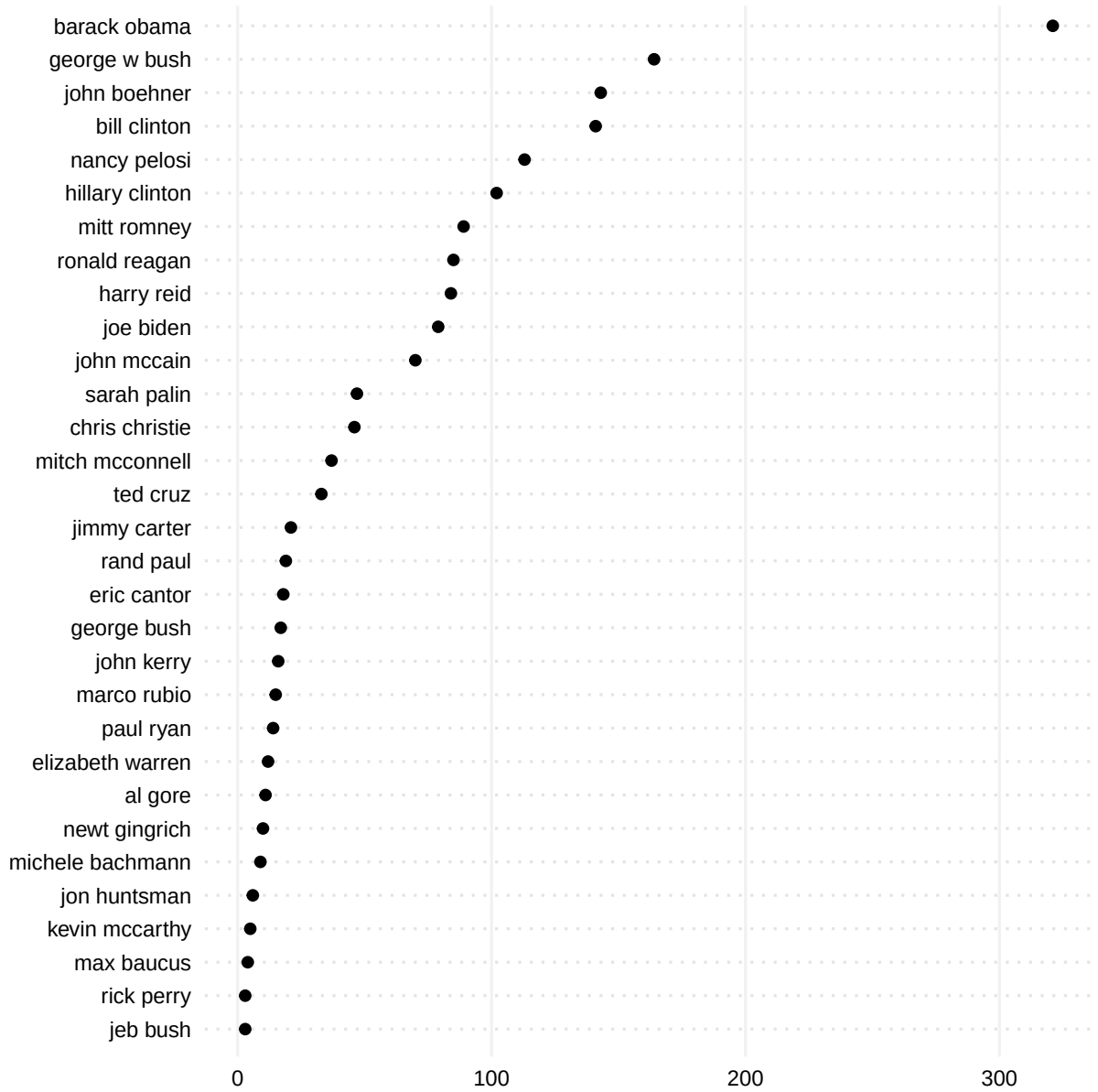
Table 1: Are Recalled Politicians More Extreme than the Median Senator of the Party?

	Extremity Compared to Senate Mean	
	(1)	(2)
Constant	0.017** (0.007)	0.094*** (0.015)
Out Party		0.069*** (0.021)
Recall Order		−0.216*** (0.024)
Out Party x Recall Order		−0.040 (0.034)
Observations	1,725	1,725
Akaike Inf. Crit.	782.323	607.624
Bayesian Inf. Crit.	798.682	640.341

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Figure 1: Distribution of Recall of Politicians. The horizontal axis counts identified, score-matched free recalls across all three positions.



References

- Berinsky, Adam J, Gregory A Huber and Gabriel S Lenz. 2012. “Evaluating online labor markets for experimental research: Amazon. com’s Mechanical Turk.” *Political Analysis* 20(3):351–368.
- Bonica, Adam. 2013. “Ideology and interests in the political marketplace.” *American Journal of Political Science* 57:294–311.

Supporting Information

SI 1 Survey data

Because the answers to the politician recall survey questions were open-ended (respondents typed in names), the responses were quite “noisy” (in addition to misspellings, some respondents just used last names, some just first names, etc) so we had to take several steps to address this. The historical coding began with politicians whose exact name was used at least 3 times for at least one of the recall questions. Then, to determine whether other respondents were attempting to refer to these politicians, we checked whether the respondent referred to the same last name (for unique last names), common misspellings of the last or first names (oboma, reed, hilary), and common stems for very difficult to spell names (boe or boh for boehner, mcon for mcconnell). The revised analysis applies the union of these historical name assignments consistently across free-recall positions. We retain the historical defaults for ambiguous Bush and Clinton responses: senior or H.W. cues identify George H.W. Bush, other ambiguous Bush responses identify George W. Bush, and ‘clinton’ identifies Bill Clinton. Explicit ‘Jeb Bush’ responses identify Jeb Bush. Prompted selections use the identities on the menu. These defaults are coding conventions for ambiguous free responses.

The analysis uses the archived static CF-score for each identified politician. Prompted selections with an available score are retained, including Jeb Bush, Ted Kennedy, and Barney Frank; John F. Kennedy and Franklin D. Roosevelt have no verified score in the archived file. Free-recall name assignments otherwise retain the historical roster. The unit of analysis is a politician–respondent mention. Means weight mentions equally, and uncertainty is clustered by respondent. We use ordinary least squares with a small-sample cluster correction and $t(G - 1)$ inference, where G is the number of respondents in the model. Independents

contribute to descriptive means but are excluded from in-party/out-party comparisons. Recall position and elicitation stage enter as categories; reported contrasts are unadjusted for multiple comparisons.

Table SI 1.1 provides a synopsis.

Table SI 1.1: Sample Demographics Compared to Benchmarks			
	Sample	2012 ANES	2010 Census
Age			
18-29	23.1%		19.2%
30-49	41.9%		31.7%
50+	35.0%		49.2%
Gender			
Male	53.2%		49.1%
Female	46.8%		50.9%
Race/Ethnicity			
White/Caucasian	87.9%		63.7%
Black/African-American	4.7%		12.2%
Asian/PI	4.3%		4.8%
Hispanic/Latino	5.0%		16.4%
Native American	1.0%		1.1%
Other/more than one	2.2%		6.2%
Education			
Less than HS degree	0.0%		8.9%
High school/GED	11.1%		31.0%
Some college/2-year degree	36.3%		28.0%
4-year college degree	41.7%		18.0%
Graduate/professional degree	10.8%		9.3%
Party Identification			
Democratic (inc. leaners)	56.8%	49.0%	
Republican (inc. leaners)	31.0%	39.0%	
No party preference/Other	12.1%	11.9%	

Note: Sample statistics are for the free-recall analysis, with N=1737 mentions from 344 respondents. Respondents who recalled more identified politicians receive more weight. White/Caucasian includes Hispanic respondents in the survey but is non-Hispanic for the Census benchmark. Hispanic origin is recorded separately from race in the survey.

SI 1.1 Recall Results

CF-scores are oriented toward the recalled politician’s party: Democratic scores are multiplied by -1 , and Republican scores retain their sign. First recalls have higher party-directed CF-scores than later recalls (Table SI 1.2). These comparisons condition on the supplied score estimates.

Table SI 1.2: CF-score Differences by Free-recall Position

Party	Comparison	Difference	95% CI
In party	Second minus first	-0.218	[-0.260, -0.176]
In party	Third minus first	-0.194	[-0.237, -0.151]
Out party	Second minus first	-0.141	[-0.183, -0.099]
Out party	Third minus first	-0.114	[-0.159, -0.069]

Note: Differences are relative to the first free recall, with respondent-clustered 95% confidence intervals. The model includes 1526 mentions from 299 Democratic or Republican respondents.

Ratings are oriented toward the recalled politician’s party and rescaled from the seven-point slider: 0 is the opposite party’s ideological endpoint, 0.5 is moderate, and 1 is the expected party’s endpoint. Table SI 1.3 reports means for the primary free-recall sample and the prompted-selection comparison. These ratings describe perceived ideological position; the rating scale and CF-score scale do not supply a calibrated measure of perceptual error.

Table SI 1.3: Perceived Ideological Position by Elicitation Task

Sample	Ratings	Respondents	Mean	95% CI
Free recall	1202	339	0.802	[0.789, 0.815]
Prompted	633	343	0.769	[0.752, 0.787]
Both tasks	1835	343	0.791	[0.778, 0.804]

Note: Mention-weighted means with respondent-clustered 95% confidence intervals. Free recall includes the first two names from each party. Prompted selections are matched to the actual selected name and its score. Independents are included.

Table SI 1.4 compares out-party and in-party ratings at each stage. The gap changes by 0.000 between the first and second free recall (95% CI [-0.033, 0.033]; $p = 0.998$). Between the first free recall and the prompted selection, the gap changes by -0.043 (95% CI

[-0.077, -0.009]; $p = 0.012$). The latter compares elicitation tasks involving different selected politicians; it is not a third free-recall position or an estimate of the causal effect of prompting.

Table SI 1.4: Out-party Minus In-party Rating Gaps

Stage	Gap	95% CI
First free recall	0.107	[0.082, 0.133]
Second free recall	0.107	[0.078, 0.136]
Prompted selection	0.064	[0.031, 0.097]

Note: Gaps and respondent-clustered 95% confidence intervals come from the party-by-stage model with 1603 ratings from 298 Democratic or Republican respondents.